

Medical Emoji Project: Microsoft Review and Standards-Sponsorship Request

Executive memo for David Rhew, Microsoft medical leadership, and Vishal Chowdhary

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Purpose: Request a focused Microsoft decision on whether to sponsor a comprehensive, bounded medical-emoji coverage review and to route the accompanying individual proposals to the appropriate Unicode working group.

Executive request

The Medical Emoji Project asks Microsoft to consider a standards-facing medical-emoji program modeled on the logic of Apple's 2018 accessibility submission: identify a meaningful coverage gap, define a bounded initial program, and submit individual concepts through Unicode's normal review process.

We are not asking Microsoft to guarantee encoding, request preferential treatment, or endorse an unlimited list of organs and medical devices. We are asking Microsoft to:

1. identify the appropriate Unicode standards owner and product/design owner;
2. review the project's medical-emoji coverage analysis and individual proposal packets;
3. decide whether Microsoft is willing to sponsor a short UTC/L2 discussion document; and
4. if so, ask the responsible Unicode working group to review the materials seriously on their technical merits.

The proposed program covers two related but distinct questions:

- **Coverage:** Which important medical concepts are currently absent or scattered across unrelated emoji categories?
- **Encoding:** Which individual concepts meet Unicode's evidence, distinctiveness, and expected-usage factors?

The L2 document should address coverage and process. Each emoji must still be submitted and evaluated separately.

Concrete L2 request

The document should ask the Unicode Technical Committee to:

1. Recognize health-related emoji coverage as a coherent standards-maintenance issue.
2. Review how anatomy, diagnostics, laboratory medicine, medication, emergency care, and clinical equipment are organized.
3. Establish criteria for prioritizing missing concepts.
4. Refer individual concepts to the normal Emoji proposal process.
5. Clarify how vendors can provide design, accessibility, and anticipated-implementation support.

What is being submitted

The project plans a comprehensive medical-emoji program with the following coverage areas:

Core medical coverage gaps

- Basic anatomy: kidney, liver, stomach, intestines, and related internal organs.
- Diagnostic monitoring: EKG/ECG.
- Laboratory medicine: white blood cell.
- Existing anatomical heart, lungs, and brain as part of the broader organization and coverage review.

Practical medical concepts

- Medication management: Pill Box and Inhaler.
- Blood care: Blood Bag and IV Bag.
- Emergency and routine care: First Aid Kit and Leg Cast.
- Clinical equipment and measurement: Weight Scale and other clearly supportable medical objects.

The immediate individual-proposal focus should be Pill Box as the leading practical concept and Blood Bag as the strongest fallback. The anatomy, EKG, and white-blood-cell concepts belong in the comprehensive coverage case, with individual packets advanced according to evidence and Unicode's procedural review.

Why this project is legitimate

The project is not a petition or a social-media campaign. It is a documented Unicode proposal effort led by an individual physician, supported by original artwork, public frequency research, prior proposal history, and professional coalition materials.

The project has four sources of legitimacy:

1. **Historical participation.** The project previously participated in successful Unicode emoji work for anatomical heart and lungs. Those characters entered the standard

through formal Unicode review, not through a petition or a corporate branding campaign.

2. **Current-format preparation.** The new packets follow Unicode's current proposal structure: identification, color and black-and-white artwork, image-rights certification, inclusion and exclusion factors, sequences, expected-usage evidence, and reproducible source records.
3. **Professional coalition support.** Medical and patient organizations have supplied letters supporting specific organ and health concepts. These materials demonstrate clinical relevance and coalition legitimacy; they are not presented as substitutes for Unicode's required frequency evidence.
4. **Vendor feasibility.** Microsoft can evaluate whether the proposed paradigms are recognizable at small sizes, accessible, compatible with Segoe UI Emoji, and supportable through ordinary product and legal review.

Professional and society support

The documented coalition includes organizations from nephrology, gastroenterology, emergency medicine, patient advocacy, and international kidney care. The support inventory includes:

- American Association of Kidney Patients.
- American Society of Nephrology.
- American Society of Diagnostic and Interventional Nephrology.
- Canadian Society of Nephrology.
- International Society of Nephrology.
- Kidney Disease: Improving Global Outcomes.
- National Kidney Foundation.
- Renal Physicians Association.
- Kidney Foundation of Western New York.
- Women Nephrology India.
- Glomerular Disease Study and Trial Consortium and NephJC.
- American Gastroenterological Association.
- American Society for Gastrointestinal Endoscopy.
- American College of Emergency Physicians, including its 2026 multi-specialty letter naming multiple anatomical and medical concepts.

The memo should describe these organizations as professional and coalition support. Unicode's expected-usage analysis must remain based on public frequency evidence, not on the number of letters or endorers.

Recommended Microsoft role

David Rhew and medical leadership

Rhew's role would be to validate the clinical communication problem, confirm that the coverage framework is medically coherent, and identify which concepts have broad everyday, clinical, educational, or emergency uses.

Microsoft standards leadership

The standards owner should determine whether Microsoft will carry a short L2 document focused on medical-emoji coverage, ordering, and a review framework. The document should request referral to the appropriate Emoji Standard and Research process, not ask the UTC to encode a slate by consensus vote.

Microsoft design and product leadership

The product owner should review Pill Box, Blood Bag, and the leading anatomy concepts at 18x18 and in true black-and-white. The review should identify which paradigms Microsoft could plausibly support if Unicode advances them.

Microsoft Legal and Communications

Legal and Communications should approve any anticipated-implementation language and any public use of Microsoft health research or Copilot-related material. Private Microsoft data should not appear in the public L2 document without explicit clearance.

The requested working-group nudge

The appropriate request is procedural and substantive, not outcome-seeking:

Microsoft respectfully asks that the attached medical-emoji coverage analysis and individual proposal materials be routed to the appropriate Unicode working group and reviewed on their complete technical merits, including the evidence, distinctiveness, public utility, image rights, and anticipated vendor-support considerations.

This wording gives the materials institutional weight without asking Unicode to approve them because Microsoft supports them. It also preserves the independence of the Emoji Standard and Research Working Group.

Decision requested from Chowdhary

Would Microsoft support a bounded medical-emoji coverage program and authorize a standards, medical, design, and legal owner to review it? If yes, would Microsoft's Unicode delegate carry the L2 discussion document and ask the working group to review the associated individual proposals through the normal process?

If the answer is no, the project will continue as an individual-submitter effort. The Microsoft review would still be valuable if it identifies one product-supported concept, particularly Pill Box or Blood Bag, and gives procedural guidance without formal sponsorship.

Guardrails

- Do not call the program a complete anatomy taxonomy.
- Do not ask Unicode to encode every listed concept at once.
- Do not use society letters as frequency evidence.
- Do not present the 2022 organ decline-date interpretation as settled in a public filing without Unicode confirmation, even though the internal program should plan for those concepts.
- Do not include repository links in public-facing versions of this memo.

Public standards references

Unicode emoji proposal guidelines: <https://www.unicode.org/emoji/proposals.html>

Apple accessibility emoji precedent, L2/18-080:

<https://www.unicode.org/L2/L2018/18080-accessibility-emoji.pdf>

Unicode document-submission guidance:

<https://www.unicode.org/pending/docsubmit.html>